

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Medium

CORE FORMULA

Specific thing -> Why it stood out -> Stop

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Give one compliment today that names the specific thing you observed and why it mattered to you. Do not add qualifiers or requests after it.

BEST FOR

- Building trust and goodwill with colleagues
- Motivating people authentically
- Strengthening relationships without flattery
- After someone does good work, especially unnoticed work

PHRASE BANK

Specific Praise · Naming the thing

- "The way you handled that question in the meeting was sharp."
- "That document was really well-structured — easy to follow."
- "I noticed how calm you stayed under pressure today."
- "The way you explained that to the client was exactly right."
- "You spotted something in the data that nobody else caught."
- "That was a good call — and I do not think it was easy to make."
- "The edit you made to that paragraph made it much clearer."
- "You handled that pushback with real composure."

Impact Phrases · Why it mattered

- "It made the difference in how the meeting landed."
- "That kind of thing does not go unnoticed."
- "I wanted to say it because I meant it."
- "I have been thinking about that since yesterday."
- "That is not a small thing — it takes skill."
- "That made my job easier and I wanted to acknowledge it."

Quick Compliments · Short, specific, in passing

- "Good catch on that error."
- "That subject line did all the work."
- "Nice framing in that email."
- "That was the right call at the right moment."
- "Clean handover — nothing missing."
- "You made that look easier than it was."

Professional Praise · Crediting work in work settings

- "Your analysis changed my mind on the timeline — I came in believing the opposite."
- "The rollout went smoothly because of the preparation, and I want that noted."
- "The way you structured that document saved the meeting twenty minutes."
- "That risk you flagged in March is exactly what just happened. Well called."
- "Your summary was the clearest statement of the problem I have heard so far."
- "The client asked who wrote the proposal. I made sure they knew."

Praise Under Pressure · Crediting people when it costs something

- "Before I push back on the plan: the thinking behind it is genuinely strong."
- "You are arguing against me and doing it well — that last point in particular lands."
- "I want to be clear in front of this room: that decision was theirs, and it was the right one."
- "I disagreed with you at the time. You were right, and the way you held your ground was impressive."
- "That was a hard message to deliver and you did it without flinching."
- "Credit where it is due, even though it weakens my case: your numbers are better than mine."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Generic: 'Great job today!'

Better: You did well in that meeting.

Best: The way you stayed calm when they pushed back — that changed the whole dynamic.

2. Weak: Compliment attached to a request

Better: You did great, and while I have you — could you...?

Best: Compliment on its own, request in a separate message.

3. Weak: Vague praise: 'You are really talented'

Better: Your presentation skills are strong.

Best: That opening line in your talk changed the energy in the room.

DECISION TREE

If You want to compliment someone but it feels generic

Name one specific thing. Drop the generic opener.

"That specific decision you made — the one about X — was really well-judged."

If You want to compliment and then ask for something

Give the compliment cleanly on its own. Make the ask separately and later.

"I just wanted to say that. No agenda — I'll follow up about the project separately."

If The person deflects or minimises your compliment

Gently hold the compliment.

"I know you will say it was nothing — I do not agree."

If You give a lot of compliments and they feel cheap

Give fewer. Choose the ones you actually mean.

"I do not say this often, but..."

SCENARIOS

Colleague who did unnoticed work well

Name the specific work and the impact it had. — "The report you put together — the structure made it really easy to use. I noticed."

Direct report who handled a difficult situation

Be specific about what they did and why it worked. — "The way you responded to that complaint was exactly right. I was impressed."

Manager who gave good feedback

Thank them specifically for what was useful. — "The feedback you gave last week on the proposal was genuinely helpful — especially the point about the opening."

Friend or partner who made an effort you noticed

Name the specific effort, not the result. — "I noticed you did X when you did not have to. I just wanted to say that."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When you are fishing for a reciprocal compliment — the motive will be sensed.
- In formal performance reviews where specific praise can inadvertently exclude other positive qualities.
- When the compliment is about something outside the person's control rather than their choices or skill.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Noticing

Observe one thing today that someone does well. Write it down but do not say it yet.

Day 2 — The specific test

Give one compliment that includes a specific observed detail.

Day 3 — No agenda

Give one compliment with nothing attached — no ask, no follow-up, no transition to another topic.

Day 4 — Delayed delivery

Tell someone something you noticed about them last week or last month that you never said.

Day 5 — Written praise

Send one short written note complimenting something specific.

Day 6 — Public vs private

Decide whether the compliment is better said privately or in front of others. Say it accordingly.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your compliments land well? Were any too vague? Did any feel forced or like performance?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name the specific thing I observed — not just 'good job'?
- Did I say why it stood out to me?
- Did I stop after the compliment rather than add a request?
- Did I mean it — or was it a social lubricant?
- Did I avoid the compliment-sandwich (compliment-criticism-compliment)?
- Did the timing feel natural, not forced?
- Did I resist over-complimenting in a way that loses meaning?